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ESOL
Listening transcript

WEDNESDAY, 13 MAY
1:00 PM – 1:45 PM (approx)

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Instructions to reader(s):

Recording 1

The conversation below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the conversation a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

Where special arrangements have been agreed in advance to allow the reading of the material, it should be read by one male and two female speakers or one female and two male speakers. Sections marked **(t)** should be read by the teacher.

(t) Recording 1

Listen to the recording and attempt the questions which follow. You will hear the recording twice. You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 1 before the recording begins.

(*1 minute pause*)

TONE

Host Welcome to The Future Now, where we debate today's big issues. Today's topic: the cashless society. Joining us is Sarah McDonald, international financial consultant and advocate for going cashless. Welcome, Sarah.

Sarah Thanks, happy to be here.

Host And Mike Harris, a small business owner who's not convinced by the digital shift. Mike, thanks for joining.

Mike Thanks for having me.

Host Let's dive straight in. Sarah, why do you support the move to cashless payments?

Sarah Well, the benefits are undeniable. For one, crime drops dramatically. Digital payments leave a trail, so it's tougher for criminals to operate under the radar of law enforcement. When cash is out of the equation, things like theft, robbery, and money laundering become much harder. Plus, technological advancements like biometrics have revolutionised fraud prevention — I'm sure many of your listeners will be familiar with facial recognition software on their banking apps, for example, which adds a personal layer of security that's now nearly impossible to break through. Cash can't compete with that.

Mike Sorry Sarah, but I think that's such a narrow view. Cybercrime opens a whole new can of worms. Digital systems are not foolproof. It used to be only rarely that massive data breaches would hit the news but now it seems like every few months personal information is leaked, credit card numbers are stolen . . .

Sarah I get it — there's always resistance to change. But let's not make this about scaring people.

Mike Well, let's not pretend this shift is good for everyone, either. Granted, I have noticed a shift in many of my regulars leaning towards making digital payments, but in my small business, I can tell you, the processing fees are killing us. The three percent charge per transaction quickly adds up when you're running on narrow margins. Not only that, but it also takes 3–5 business days before I actually see any of that money in my bank account. I don't have that issue with cash.

Sarah But Mike, the world isn't going to stop moving forward because small businesses find going cashless a little inconvenient. Cash is cumbersome, especially in an increasingly globalised economy.

Mike That's easy for you to say when you're sitting in your cushy office, travelling all over the world, living in the lap of luxury.

Sarah That's a bit uncalled for . . .

Mike Well, not everyone lives in a world where broadband is perfect and smartphones are in every hand. My shop — the only one for miles around — offers services to a rural community, many of whom are retired people. Don't get me wrong, we've got solid mobile network coverage, but many customers are extremely uncomfortable trying — and failing — to get to grips with technology. We can't just go around alienating a huge chunk of the population. So, of course I accept cash.

Host And I believe you have a concern about confidentiality too?

Mike Absolutely. Every time we swipe a card or tap a phone, companies are harvesting our data, watching every transaction. Cash gives people privacy, something your so-called 'convenient' system is erasing.

Sarah Oh, come on. The privacy argument is a bit outdated, don't you think? Digital services are already used daily — social media, online shopping, booking systems. If you're using a smartphone, chances are your movements are already being tracked, whether you like it or not. At least with digital transactions, we can build security into the system so we can minimise any potential danger. I get that people are uncomfortable with the idea of companies and governments having access to their financial data, but let's not pretend cash is some perfectly secure alternative. Criminals thrive on cash because it's untraceable. If anything, information gained from the processing of digital payments allows for a level of oversight and accountability — which to me is a crucial element of financial management — that cash simply can't provide.

Mike Nonsense . . .

Host Okay, let me jump in here. Thank you both for your contributions . . . Clearly, the debate over a cashless society is far from settled . . . (*fade out*)

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

TONE

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

TONE

[Turn over

Instructions to reader(s):

Recording 2

The conversation below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the conversation a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

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(t) Recording 2

Listen to the recording and attempt the questions which follow. You will hear the recording twice. You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 2 before the recording begins.

(*1 minute pause*)

TONE

Host Hello and welcome to today's show. Our guest today, Anna Greenberg, is an infectious disease researcher who found herself juggling a newborn and a career-defining opportunity at the World Health Organization. Anna, what was going through your mind when you were offered the chance to talk to W.H.O.?

Anna I'd been working really hard for years so I could hit the ground running, and was ready to present my findings on vaccine policy — it felt like a dream come true. But soon, reality hit me pretty hard. The committee meeting was in Switzerland, and I'm based in Australia. That meant a 24-hour flight and a huge time difference. Worst of all, I'd just finished maternity leave, with a 9-month-old baby. I immediately thought, 'How on earth am I going to make this work?'

Host Wow! What were your options at that point?

Anna I saw two possibilities: either I didn't go, or I took my baby with me. Leaving him at home wasn't an option for me even though my family offered to mind him while I was away. I'd just stopped breastfeeding and felt that a special new bond had formed between us and I just wasn't ready to be away from him for so long. But travelling internationally with a baby — yeah, that was a daunting task ahead. But at least I knew it was only going to be a few days, and then I could head back home.

Host I bet! Did you know anyone who had done something like this before?

Anna Actually, no. I asked around, but no one I knew had done so, and my mum was keen on trying to talk me out of it. But I was sure I couldn't be the first to have considered it, so I turned to internet blog posts. These provided a wealth of information from people who'd had similar experiences, which convinced me I could do it. I even contacted a few different air carrier companies to ask about travelling with a baby, but I came up with practically nothing.

Host So how did you make it work logistically?

Anna It was definitely a challenge! Flying 24 hours with a baby is no joke. There was a moment on the flight where my baby fell asleep, and I, as well as many of my fellow passengers, crashed out too, only to have my nap interrupted by cabin crew tapping me on the shoulder because my son was screaming!

Host Sounds exhausting!

Anna To add to that, when I arrived, there wasn't an on-site nursery so I was concerned that I'd have to take my son into the meetings. But then I remembered a colleague who once brought a nanny to an event, so I reached out to my employer to see if they would help, but they didn't have anybody they could source at short notice, so I had to figure out childcare myself. Thankfully, once I found a suitable person, my manager agreed to provide funding, which was a relief.

Host That sounds intense. What was it like when the nanny arrived?

Anna Although she came with a glowing reference, I was nervous at first about someone I'd never met looking after my son. But I needn't have worried — she turned out to be really warm and experienced. The baby had a few meltdowns, of course, but overall it worked really well.

Host And how did the meeting go? Were you able to focus with everything going on?

Anna Surprisingly, yes! The nanny would send me hourly messages, which I had thought might bother colleagues, but they didn't even seem to notice. I had been worried about them questioning my professionalism if they found out I'd travelled with my baby, but those fears were unfounded. Although I wasn't given any preferential treatment, everyone was supportive, and many were amazed that I was able to attend at all.

Host Sounds like you pulled it off! Any key takeaways from this experience?

Anna It wasn't easy, but it was worth it. I hope my story shows that with creativity and support, it is possible to fulfil your dreams.

Host What a story! Thanks for sharing that with us today!

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

TONE

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

TONE

[Turn over

Instructions to reader(s):

Recording 3

The conversation below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the conversation a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

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(t) Recording 3

Listen to the recording and attempt the questions which follow. You will hear the recording twice. You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 3 before the recording begins.

(*1 minute pause*)

TONE

Justin The weather is bright over most of the country today but you will see some occasional showers in the Northwest, particularly on the higher ground. Now, on The Education Programme today, Sabine Hutton reflects on our obsession with exams and where it's taking us. Sabine, over to you . . .

Sabine So, over the next few days, hundreds of thousands of young people will get their exam results. In many cases, these will represent years of study, boiled down to a few hours in an exam hall. But for a lot of those young people, once the results are in, the memories of exams will rapidly fade. All that training — the cramming of quotes, the learning of formulas — may never be used again.

So why do we put our young people through this? Part of the answer is that grades matter. I'm a teacher, and when I say to my students that the marks they get will determine the paths they take, it is absolutely true. Entry into professions like nursing, once regarded as practical and non-academic, now requires a degree. In England, Maths and English qualifications are necessary to continue into the final years of school, even if you want to study art or plumbing. And while it's generally known that university entrance has precise entry criteria, to promote the courses university marketing departments have also recently added projected earnings for graduates.

But in a society where opportunities seem to be getting fewer and fewer by the day, the process of getting those grades has become overwhelmingly intense. Meanwhile, schools are subject to a system of accountability that says that teachers must get every last mark for the students we teach, which makes it hard for us to avoid transferring our anxiety to them. That isn't healthy.

So what's the alternative to making everything depend on the big exam taken in May or June? There are lots of other kinds of assessment promoted by educational reformers, but there are drawbacks to everything. More coursework sounds attractive, but is criticised as opening the door to even greater unfairness, given how much parents or private tutors can help if pupils have the option to complete the work at home. Continuous assessment — giving tests all year round, not just in May or June, is seen as a kinder option — but in reality, it just distributes the pressure in different ways.

And one of the most powerful features of an exam-based syllabus, when it's well designed and well taught, is that by putting assessment to the end, it can cement understanding in powerful ways. If it is poorly designed, of course, it can do the opposite. I've just finished teaching creative writing. I'm a novelist, and I threw myself into this with enthusiasm. But when marking my students' papers with a colleague, we realised that they were being penalised simply because of the lack of semi-colons in their writing. Without them, they failed to meet the criterion of 'varied punctuation'. Highly specific mark schemes don't always recognise individual judgment and craft.

But that is an argument for better exams, not no exams. The thing is, exams are just a tool. They work for some things, and not for others.

At the moment, we have a system that believes in meritocracy — as if there is equality of opportunity for every child at school. In reality, in an unequal society, exams simply repeat existing privilege. The need to constantly make small, precise differences between students, in order to rank them in a kind of league table, is detrimental for education. But exams don't have to be used in this hyper-competitive way. What if, for example, we thought of them as being like driving licences, an indicator that you've achieved a standard, universal level of competence? Or a bit like belts in judo or karate, where ranking is a better reflection of the amount of time and effort you have put in? All in all, we need to give young people suffering in our current exam system a much better deal.

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

TONE

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

(t) You now have one minute to check your answers.

(*1 minute pause*)

(t) This is the end of the listening test.

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